Saivite Saints (63 Nayanmars)



There are 63 legendary Nayanmars. Among them, Gnanasampandar, Appar, and Sundarar (often called "the trio") are worshipped as saints through their images in South Indian temples. Nambi Andar Nambi (1000 A.D.) is said to have compiled the songs of all of the Nayanmars that form the basis of *Tirumurai*, the basic Tamil Saivite sacred canon. It consists of 12 books, and 11 of them were assembled by Nambi. The 12th book is Sekkizhar's *Periyapuranam*.

(a) Adi Shankara



Adi Shankara

Adi Shankara or Shankarachariar (c. 700–750 A.D.) preached the *Advaita* philosophy. The essence of this philosophy is that the soul (*atma*) unites with the universal soul (*brahma*) through the attainment of knowledge. He set up *mathas* (*mutts*), centres of learning and worship, at Badrinath, Puri, Dwarka and Sringeri. These places have become prominent pilgrim centres today. Shankara enthusiastically endeavoured to restore the orthodox Vedic tradition without paying attention to the Bhakti movement of his time. His masterpiece is the commentary on the *Brahma-sutra*, which is a fundamental text of the Vedanta school. His commentaries on the principal Upanishads are also considered equally important.

(b) Ramanuja



Ramanuja

Ramanuja, a 11th century Vaishnava saint, was the most influential thinker of Vaishnavism. His philosophy, known as *vishistadvaita,* proclaims that the soul retains its identity even after uniting with *brahma.* After a long pilgrimage, Ramanuja settled in Srirangam. Ramanuja articulated ideas of social equality and condemned caste-based restrictions on entering the temples. He established centres to spread his doctrine of devotion, *Srivaishnavism,* to God Vishnu and his consort Lakshmi.

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In the 16th and 17th centuries, Vaishnavism spread across India. The Vadakalai Vaishnavism originally flourished around Kanchipuram, which was a popular

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